

Vietnamese Women at War

The war profoundly altered life for Vietnamese women on both sides of the conflict. Even those who did not actively participate in the war effort experienced terrible hardships, including the violent deaths of loved ones, homelessness, and hunger.

◀ BEFORE

Vietnamese history and legend feature several female warriors, but the lives of most Vietnamese women before the war revolved around the home.

LIFE VERSUS LEGEND

The **Trung Sisters** led a rebellion against China in the first century CE. Two hundred years later, **Trieu Au**, a “Vietnamese Joan of Arc,” reputedly rode into battle against the Chinese on an elephant. Despite such examples, women **struggled to assert their place** in society—religious beliefs, Confucian principles, and custom often limited their influence to family and home.

The wars of the 20th century created opportunities for Vietnamese women, because their labor and skills were too valuable not to be utilized in the fight for national independence. Traditional Vietnamese culture offered women few options beyond being wives and mothers, but in wartime, they often assumed more public roles.

A wider family

Family was—and remains—of paramount importance to the Vietnamese people, and the communists were quick to exploit the power of family to mobilize political support. They argued that one’s family did not just consist of blood relations but of the entire Vietnamese nation, and that service to the nation was therefore also service to one’s family. By framing political struggle in this way, the communists encouraged many women to step into roles previously reserved for men.

North Vietnam

In North Vietnam, women worked to produce uniforms and supplies for the North Vietnamese Army (NVA). They also served in local militias, providing security to their communities and even capturing downed US airmen. Thousands of teenage girls volunteered for service maintaining the Ho Chi Minh Trail, including disarming unexploded artillery shells and mines. Women also worked as porters on the trail, pushing heavy bicycles or carrying boxes on their backs for hundreds of miles.

Women were among the North Vietnamese support personnel who went south to provide medical care, organize logistics, and serve as spies in support of the NVA and the Viet Cong. They lived in danger and deprivation, returning home to North Vietnam only at war’s end. Conditions were difficult, especially for women. They lacked sanitary supplies to care for themselves, and many were rendered unable to bear children due to poor diet and constant stress.